ENGLISH C1 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Relative clauses in discourse

Use sentential which, nominal relatives and complex preposition relatives to connect evaluation and reference across clauses. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use relative clauses in discourse to comment on a whole proposition or package an unspecified referent as a clause while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Use sentential which, nominal relatives and complex preposition relatives to connect evaluation and reference across clauses.

MODEL

The deadline was extended, which gave the team time to retest.

clause, which + comment | what/where/how + clause | prep + which/whom

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main relative clauses in discourse patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses comment on a whole proposition or package an unspecified referent as a clause.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in analytical writing, narrative commentary and formal explanation.

Build meaning before form

Use sentential which, nominal relatives and complex preposition relatives to connect evaluation and reference across clauses.

What relative clauses in discourse communicates

Use sentential which, nominal relatives and complex preposition relatives to connect evaluation and reference across clauses.

The central purpose is to comment on a whole proposition or package an unspecified referent as a clause. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

The deadline was extended, which gave the team time to retest.	a comment on the entire preceding proposition
What the review revealed was a failure of oversight.	an unspecified thing or idea functioning as a noun phrase
The principles on the basis of which the decision was made remain unclear.	a formal relationship expressed by a multiword preposition

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: clause, which + comment | what/where/how + clause | prep + which/whom. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “The deadline was extended, which gave the team time to retest.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Sentential relative	clause, which + comment	The deadline was extended, which gave the team time to retest.
Nominal relative	what/where/how + clause	What the review revealed was a failure of oversight.
Complex preposition relative	preposition phrase + which/whom	The principles on the basis of which the decision was made remain unclear.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
a comment on the entire preceding proposition	Sentential relative
an unspecified thing or idea functioning as a noun phrase	Nominal relative
a formal relationship expressed by a multiword preposition	Complex preposition relative

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in analytical writing, narrative commentary and formal explanation. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03	04	05	06
clause, which	comment	what/where/how	clause	prep	which/whom

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: comment on a whole proposition or package an unspecified referent as a clause.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits analytical writing, narrative commentary and formal explanation.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Sentential relative	clause, which + comment	The deadline was extended, which gave the team time to retest.
Nominal relative	what/where/how + clause	What the review revealed was a failure of oversight.
Complex preposition relative	preposition phrase + which/whom	The principles on the basis of which the decision was made remain unclear.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

The deadline was extended, which gave the team time to retest.	a comment on the entire preceding proposition
What the review revealed was a failure of oversight.	an unspecified thing or idea functioning as a noun phrase
The principles on the basis of which the decision was made remain unclear.	a formal relationship expressed by a multiword preposition

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not attach which ambiguously to a nearby noun when it refers to the whole clause.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not add an antecedent before a fused nominal relative with what.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use that after a fronted complex preposition.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a comment on the entire preceding proposition?

OPTIONS The deadline was extended, which gave the team time to retest. · What the review revealed was a failure of oversight. · The principles on the basis of which the decision was made remain unclear.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: an unspecified thing or idea functioning as a noun phrase?

OPTIONS What the review revealed was a failure of oversight. · The principles on the basis of which the decision was made remain unclear. · The deadline was extended, which gave the team time to retest.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a formal relationship expressed by a multiword preposition?

OPTIONS The principles on the basis of which the decision was made remain unclear. · The deadline was extended, which gave the team time to retest. · What the review revealed was a failure of oversight.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “The deadline was extended, which gave the team time to retest.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a comment on the entire preceding proposition · an unspecified thing or idea functioning as a noun phrase · a formal relationship expressed by a multiword preposition

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “What the review revealed was a failure of oversight.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS an unspecified thing or idea functioning as a noun phrase · a formal relationship expressed by a multiword preposition · a comment on the entire preceding proposition

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “The principles on the basis of which the decision was made remain unclear.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a formal relationship expressed by a multiword preposition · a comment on the entire preceding proposition · an unspecified thing or idea functioning as a noun phrase

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

02 · PRACTICE STAGE

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

“The deadline was extended, which gave the team time to retest.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Sentential relative / Nominal relative / Complex preposition relative · Gap 2: a comment on the entire preceding proposition / an unspecified thing or idea functioning as a noun phrase / a formal relationship expressed by a multiword preposition

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

“What the review revealed was a failure of oversight.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Nominal relative / Complex preposition relative / Sentential relative · Gap 2: an unspecified thing or idea functioning as a noun phrase / a formal relationship expressed by a multiword preposition / a comment on the entire preceding proposition

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

“The principles on the basis of which the decision was made remain unclear.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Complex preposition relative / Sentential relative / Nominal relative · Gap 2: a formal relationship expressed by a multiword preposition / a comment on the entire preceding proposition / an unspecified thing or idea functioning as a noun phrase

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses a comment on the entire preceding proposition: _____. Choose the model that expresses an unspecified thing or idea functioning as a noun phrase: _____. Choose the model that expresses a formal relationship expressed by a multiword preposition: _____. Choose the model built with clause, which + comment: _____. Choose the model built with what/where/how + clause: _____. Choose the model built with preposition phrase + which/whom: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

The deadline was extended, which gave the team time to retest. · The principles on the basis of which the decision was made remain unclear. · What the review revealed was a failure of oversight.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

The deadline was extended, _____ to retest. _____ was a failure of oversight. The principles _____ the decision was made remain unclear. State the full structural pattern for Sentential relative: _____. State the full structural pattern for Nominal relative: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “The extension gave the team more time.” using the Sentential relative pattern to express a comment on the entire preceding proposition.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “The review revealed a failure of oversight.” using the Nominal relative pattern to express an unspecified thing or idea functioning as a noun phrase.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “The decision was based on principles that remain unclear.” using the Complex preposition relative pattern to express a formal relationship expressed by a multiword preposition.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “The extension gave the team more time.” using the Sentential relative pattern to express a comment on the entire preceding proposition.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Sentential relative to express a comment on the entire preceding proposition, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Nominal relative to express an unspecified thing or idea functioning as a noun phrase, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Complex preposition relative to express a formal relationship expressed by a multiword preposition, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

The deadline was extended, which gave the team time to retest.

Sentential relative is the best match because a comment on the entire preceding proposition.

A2

What the review revealed was a failure of oversight.

Nominal relative is the best match because an unspecified thing or idea functioning as a noun phrase.

A3

The principles on the basis of which the decision was made remain unclear.

Complex preposition relative is the best match because a formal relationship expressed by a multiword preposition.

A4

a comment on the entire preceding proposition

The Sentential relative pattern communicates a comment on the entire preceding proposition.

A5

an unspecified thing or idea functioning as a noun phrase

The Nominal relative pattern communicates an unspecified thing or idea functioning as a noun phrase.

A6

a formal relationship expressed by a multiword preposition

The Complex preposition relative pattern communicates a formal relationship expressed by a multiword preposition.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Sentential relative / a comment on the entire preceding proposition

The structure belongs to the Sentential relative pattern. Its communicative purpose is a comment on the entire preceding proposition.

B2

Nominal relative / an unspecified thing or idea functioning as a noun phrase

The structure belongs to the Nominal relative pattern. Its communicative purpose is an unspecified thing or idea functioning as a noun phrase.

B3

Complex preposition relative / a formal relationship expressed by a multiword preposition

The structure belongs to the Complex preposition relative pattern. Its communicative purpose is a formal relationship expressed by a multiword preposition.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

The deadline was extended, which gave the team time to retest.

Sentential relative: clause, which + comment.

C2

What the review revealed was a failure of oversight.

Nominal relative: what/where/how + clause.

C3

The principles on the basis of which the decision was made remain unclear.

Complex preposition relative: preposition phrase + which/whom.

C4

The deadline was extended, which gave the team time to retest.

Sentential relative: clause, which + comment.

C5

What the review revealed was a failure of oversight.

Nominal relative: what/where/how + clause.

C6

The principles on the basis of which the decision was made remain unclear.

Complex preposition relative: preposition phrase + which/whom.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

which gave the team time

Sentential relative requires “which gave the team time” in this model. clause, which + comment.

D2

What the review revealed

Nominal relative requires “What the review revealed” in this model. what/where/how + clause.

D3

on the basis of which

Complex preposition relative requires “on the basis of which” in this model. preposition phrase + which/whom.

D4

clause, which + comment

Sentential relative is built as clause, which + comment.

D5

what/where/how + clause

Nominal relative is built as what/where/how + clause.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

The deadline was extended, which gave the team time to retest.

clause, which + comment. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended sentential relative effect.

E2

What the review revealed was a failure of oversight.

what/where/how + clause. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended nominal relative effect.

E3

The principles on the basis of which the decision was made remain unclear.

preposition phrase + which/whom. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended complex preposition relative effect.

E4

The deadline was extended, which gave the team time to retest.

clause, which + comment. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended sentential relative effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

The deadline was extended, which gave the team time to retest. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses clause, which + comment accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

What the review revealed was a failure of oversight. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses what/where/how + clause accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

The principles on the basis of which the decision was made remain unclear. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses preposition phrase + which/whom accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____